

What else to watch: *The 400 Blows* (1959, pp.150–55) ■ *Last Year at Marienbad* (1961, pp.170–71) ■ *Jules et Jim* (1962, p.334) ■ *A Hard Day's Night* (1964) ■ *Band of Outsiders* (1964) ■ *Bonnie and Clyde* (1967, pp.190–91) ■ *Pulp Fiction* (1994, pp.270–75)

“I don’t know if I’m unhappy because I’m not free, or if I’m not free because I’m unhappy.”

Patricia / À bout de souffle

movie, also had an American girlfriend, but Godard wrote the script as he filmed.

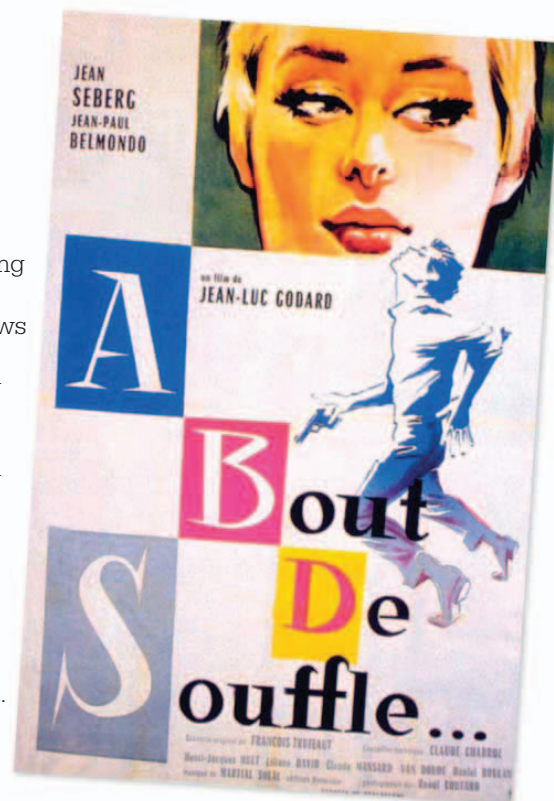
He was deliberately chaotic in his shooting method, filming on busy Paris streets, snatching shots on the run, and improvising dialogue. To work in this way, he needed to shoot with a handheld camera and in low light conditions, and this is partly what gives the movie its high contrast monochrome look. It also led to a distinctive new cinematic technique: the jump cut.

Jump cuts

Previously, one of the requirements for a well-made movie had always been complete continuity between clips shot from different angles or on different days. However, Godard made no attempt to make a smooth

transition between shots, splicing them together in a fast-moving montage. In one scene that follows Patricia driving in a sports car, the background jumps instantly from one place to another as different shots are spliced together. The jump cut has now become a staple of filmmaking, but at the time critic Bosley Crowther complained that it was a “pictorial cacophony.”

It was not just the movie’s jump cuts that created controversy, but also its coolness. Its young hero’s self-obsessed detachment and disdain for authority became hallmarks of movie for the new generation. As the 1960s began, filmmakers and audiences embraced rebellion over the self-sacrificing heroism portrayed in previous decades. ■



À bout de souffle was the first movie of the French New Wave. Its bold visual style and break from the classic studio style were implied in the movie’s poster.



Jean-Luc Godard Director

Jean-Luc Godard was born in Paris in 1930. In his early 20s, he joined Paris’s ciné-club scene and took up film criticism. Encouraged by François Truffaut, another young critic turned filmmaker, Godard began to make his own movies. His first major movie, *À bout de souffle*, took the world by storm with its new style. But Godard’s work soon became even more radical, both in look—with movies such as *Contempt*, *Band of Outsiders* (1964), and *Alphaville*

(1965)—and politically, in movies such as *A Married Woman* and *Pierrot le Fou* (1965). In the late 1960s, Godard walked away from commercial cinema completely, but continued to make movies that pushed the boundaries of the medium.

Key movies

1960 *À bout de souffle*
1963 *Contempt*
1964 *A Married Woman*